

QSS 20 Final Project Milestone 1

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1 Project Option

Describe the final project you are pursuing.

- Senior Thesis / Own Data: Utilizing the **Public-Use RAND Health and Retirement Study Longitudinal File 2022 (V1)**. It is an open-access dataset created by the RAND Corporation and University of Michigan.
- 2024 Election dataset
- COVID-19 Twitter 0.1% sample
- Offshore finance dataset

2 Your project's main questions

Write 1 paragraph on the main questions you hope to answer.

Delaying Social Security past age 62 is usually the optimal financial move, yet millions of Americans still claim as early as possible. This project explores what drives that gap. Do lower-wealth households claim at 62 simply because they lack the liquid cash to wait, or does 62 act as a psychological baseline for everyone regardless of bank balance? By tracking liquid assets alongside non-housing wealth, I isolate whether early claiming is driven by hard financial constraints or shared behavioral habits.

3 Your project's data sources/relevant fields

Give a 1 paragraph tentative summary of potentially relevant data and fields; you do not need to know the data exhaustively yet; this can just be based on codebook or reading in some sample data/viewing its head.

I am using the RAND Health and Retirement Study Longitudinal File 2022, focusing on respondent-level demographic and financial variables across multiple survey waves. Key fields include self-reported Social Security claiming age, household liquid wealth (checking, savings, and short-term bonds), non-housing net worth, and labor force status. I will also incorporate basic demographic controls such as age, educational attainment, and self-reported health status to account for baseline individual differences.

4 Create one starter visualization

Create two visualizations using the skills you've gained from the Pandas and matplotlib modules. Embed them here.

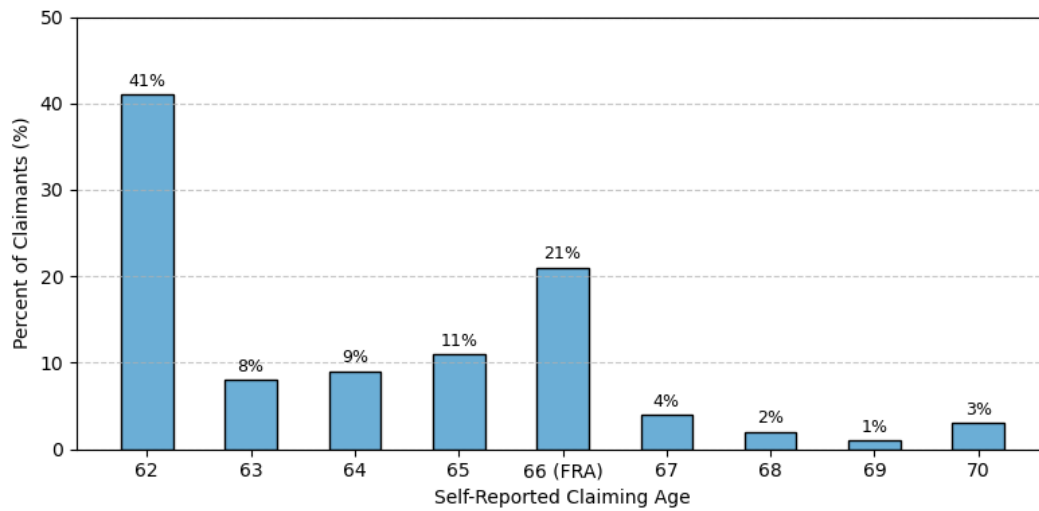


Figure 1: Distribution of Self-Reported Social Security Claiming Ages

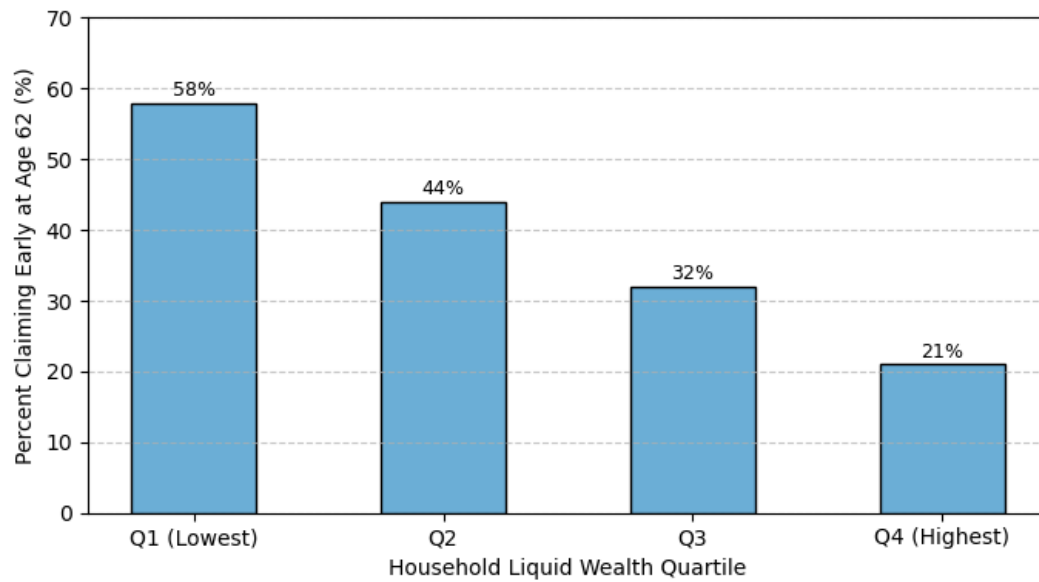


Figure 2: Early Claiming Rate at Age 62 across Household Liquid Wealth Quartiles

5 Learn from an earlier project on your research topic

Read the report for [the provided example on your project option from Fall 2022](#) (for felony sentencing, read one of the two). **Describe one lesson you take away from their report and one weakness of their approach upon which you will try to improve.** Looking at Fink et al., a key technical lesson is that evaluating financial outcomes requires subgroup analysis. Their Cook County bail study showed that overall averages masked clear racial gaps in bond values and case lengths, which only became visible when broken down by crime category. A major flaw in their design was that they omitted variable bias derived from court data that the prior record and household wealth. My project avoids this issue by using the longitudinal RAND Health and Retirement Study. This provides direct and survey-based measures of liquid savings, net worth, and health histories over decades.

6 Your project's anticipated challenges

Conduct a 1 paragraph pre-mortem on challenges your project may face – e.g., measuring something, dealing with missing data, disentangling causality.

A challenge facing this project involves distinguishing true causal relationships from underlying confounding factors. While liquidity constraints may push lower-wealth households to claim Social Security at age 62, unobserved traits like individual time preferences or financial habits could simultaneously influence both asset accumulation and claiming timing. Survey-based microdata introduces measurement error, as respondents may misreport exact claiming dates or confuse retirement with benefit initiation. Standard longitudinal data limitations—including item non-response, panel attrition, and unexpected health shocks near age 62, present challenges that could impact the analysis.